

TUESDAY, SEPTEMBER 29, 2026



The Indian EXPRESS

JOURNALISM of COURAGE

NEW DELHI, LATE CITY, 24 PAGES

₹7.00 (₹8 RAIPUR, ₹15 SRINAGAR) • www.indianexpress.com

DAILY FROM: AHMEDABAD, CHANDIGARH, DELHI, JAIPUR, KOLKATA, LUCKNOW, MUMBAI, NAGPUR, PATNA, PUNE, VADODARA

ALL EYES ON FESTIVAL SEASON DEMAND

Industrial output up 8% in August, FMCG a slow spot

Manufacturing, favourable base effect behind strong IIP growth

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, September 28

THE INDIAN economy continued its impressive run with data released Monday by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation showing industrial production in August was 8% higher compared to the same month last year. The overall growth was driven by a favourable base effect and the manufacturing



sector whose output rose 9%. Policymakers, however, will keep an eye on the consumer goods segment. While production of durable goods rose 11.1% in August, following up a 12% increase in July, non-durable goods, which are primarily fast-moving consumer products or FMCG, saw a growth of only 2.1%. Rajani Sinha, Chief Economist at CareEdge Ratings, said the overall strong industrial performance was in line with other data such as GDP growth, lending and exports, indicating

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

IIP growth

that the economy had “held up well” despite persistent global uncertainties and elevated energy prices. While the performance of consumer durables, Sinha said, continued to be a positive for consumption, “the feeble performance of consumer non-durables remains concerning”.

Consumer durables and non-durables are key indicators of household demand. And while production of durables is strong, analysts have been sounding caution ahead of the festival season, which sees Indians splurging on new purchases. But with prices of consumer electronics rising for a variety of reasons — significantly more expensive memory chips and other key inputs such as copper and aluminum as well as increasing freight costs — demand may face headwinds.

However, Indians are seen relying on loans to make purchases, with UBS analysts predicting last week that India is entering a “strong unsecured credit growth cycle, led by personal loans”. Latest data from the Reserve Bank of India shows that while personal loans given by banks were up 16.2% as of the end of July, those given by non-banks were up 21.4%.

Industrial growth as per the Index of Industrial Production (IIP) was 7.4% in July and 4.7% in August 2026. The IIP comprises four key sectors, with manufacturing accounting for three-fourths of the entire index.

The August industrial growth print of 8% is the latest in a series of robust economic numbers, with June having posted an expansion of 8.8%, the highest since 19% in March 2024. So far in the first five months of 2026-27, or April-August 2026, industrial growth has averaged 6.7%, well above 4.2% in the same period of 2025-26.

Madan Sabnavis, Chief Economist at Bank of Baroda, said, "If this is maintained, India can register growth of 7-8% for the year on the back of higher growth during the festival season with demand building up. This makes the third quarter very critical for industry."

A favourable base effect usually occurs when output either stagnated or fell in the year-ago month which is used to calculate the growth rate for the latest month. As such, this favourable base meant the year-

E. EXPLAINED

Encouraging data

After a faster-than-expected GDP growth of 7.8% in April-June, despite headwinds from the West Asia conflict, the monthly data continues to be encouraging. The festive season will be a key gauge of demand, with the weak monsoon and rising prices seen as drags on consumption.

on-year growth rates in August 2026 for industrial output as a whole and the manufacturing sector were impressive even though production was down compared to July 2026: manufacturing output was down 1.4%, while overall industrial production was 1.8% lower.

According to Rahul Agrawal, Principal Economist at ratings agency ICRA, the favourable base effect in August 2026 was because of 'inventory recalibration' in August 2025 ahead of the widely-expected cuts in the GST rates, that were announced by the GST Council in early September 2025 and came into effect later that month.

Within the manufacturing sector, 18 of the 23 categories posted higher year-on-year growth in their output in August. According to Devendra Pant, Chief Economist at India Ratings & Research, this underlined "generalised improvement".

"Like previous months, electrical equipment and motor vehicles continued to record strong growth of 30.9% and 25.2%, respectively," Pant said, adding that the former's performance was indicative of "growing domestic and external demand for Indian manufactured electrical goods."

The sharpest sectoral month-on-month fall in August was for mining and quarrying, whose output slumped 9.2% from July. Mining and quarrying, which accounts for over a tenth of the IIP, usually suffers during the monsoon as rain hinders mining activity. On a year-on-year basis, mining and quarrying output was down 5.6% in August.

A favourable base also helped push up the output of the 'electricity and gas supply' sector to 12.3% in August, although it was the only sector to post a sequential improvement in production. However, this month-on-month output increase was a mere 0.3%.

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 28

PRAHAAR stands for the seven pillars of - Prevention, Response, Aggregating Internal Capacities, Human Rights, Attenuating Conditions for Terrorism, Aligning International Efforts, and Recovery and Resilience.

He stressed the need to strengthen the PRAHAAR strategy through continuous analysis of terror incidents and by establishing a concrete mechanism for the next 10 years.



which he said would help expedite efforts to bring back fugitives from abroad, and urged state police forces to set up teams dedicated to fugitive tracking.

The conference is ex-

Shah said that between 2019 and 2026, the Modi government had brought back 288 fugitive criminals to India from 36 countries. He also said improved coordination among agencies had helped bust more than 40 modules of the Shahzad Bhatti Network, which was allegedly involved in cross-border smuggling of weapons, explosives and narcotics.

At 70%, India’s water reserves hit 10-year low

Anjali Marar
Bengaluru, September 28

EVEN AS THE southwest monsoon season for this year is set to come to an end on September 30, water storage in 178 reservoirs across the country stands at 70% of the total capacity, according to a live reservoir storage report compiled by the Central Water Commission (CWC). This is below the decadal average (10-year average stock during this period every year) of 76.62%. The 2026 stocks are also below that of 2025 stocks for the same period (79%).

The findings of the report, dated September 24, coincide with drought declarations in Maharashtra and Karnataka.

The CWC report has particularly painted a grim picture of water storage in 92 reservoirs located in the south, east and northern India regions. South India (Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Karnataka, Kerala and Tamil Nadu) has the lowest water reserves this year, with 50% water (27926 billion cubic metre) against 87.25% last year. The region has received 23% below normal rainfall, as on September 28, per India Meteorological Department (IMD) data.

Southwest monsoon brings over 70 per cent of India’s annual rainfall. One of the factors shrouding the monsoon season is the El Nino. As of September 28, India received rainfall 12% short of the normal.

Make statutory rules to bar social media firms from adding minors: SC to Govt

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, September 28

THE SUPREME COURT on Monday asked the Centre to put in place statutory rules to ensure that social media platforms and other digital intermediaries comply with Indian laws on minors and make 18 years of age the minimum requirement for extending membership.

“Our request to you, as the Government of India, you please pass some directions under the intermediary rules that they should fashion their software or platform in conformity with Indian law. They must conform at least in respect of membership of a minimum threshold of 18 years,” Justice Joyimalya Bagchi, who was part of a three-judge bench, said.

The bench, presided by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, was considering a petition by the NGO Just Rights for Children Alliance, seeking measures to bar minors from creating and operating social media accounts.

The PIL, filed through advocate Saksham Maheshwari, pointed out that children below the age of 18 years are currently permitted to independently create and maintain social media accounts despite their statutory incapacity to enter a

contract under Section 11 of the Indian Contract Act.

On September 10, the bench, also comprising Justice V. Mohana, had issued notices to the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology, the Ministry of Law and Justice and the Ministry of Labour on the petition.

On Monday, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the government, agreed with senior advocate H S Phoolka that minors cannot enter into contracts under the Indian law.

Justice Bagchi pointed out that the argument is that “they (social media intermediaries) are registered under the laws of the United States, (and) they have imported into Indian digital space the restrictions which are applicable in the US”.

“Yes, we will have to control the intermediaries”, said Mehta.

Justice Bagchi said that the government should act to get the intermediaries to follow Indian laws. CJI Kant said that the government can invoke sections 4 and 9 of the Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021, to issue directions to the intermediaries. To that, Mehta said, “Government is ready to do that. I have no manner of doubt.”

Justice Bagchi said, “They must conform at least in respect

of membership of minimum threshold of 18 years,” adding, “Please examine the intermediary rules where there is a direction to that effect...”

The PIL has urged the court to direct the government to ensure that minors are not permitted to enter into contracts with digital platforms, including social media, but they be permitted access to educational content through accounts maintained and controlled by their parents or guardians.

The petition seeks directions to social media platforms to implement effective age-assurance mechanisms and to stop allowing independent accounts of minors. The PIL pointed out that there is a “fundamental legal and regulatory inconsistency” in minors accessing social media. “Under Section 3 of the Majority Act, 1875, a person attains majority only upon completing 18 years. Under Section 11 of the Indian Contract Act, 1872, a person who has not attained the age of majority is not competent to contract”.

Social media platforms operating in India presently permit minors, generally aged 13 years and above, to independently create and maintain accounts by merely declaring their age or date of birth, the petition said.

CEC must correct course, not just do damage control

WHEN THE Election Commission of India met on Saturday, for the first time after this newspaper’s investigation into the disquiet within, it did well to break an untenable silence. In the immediate aftermath of it coming to light that two of the three Election Commissioners had recorded their objections, 14 times in 10 months, on the Commission’s decision-making — on matters relating to registering new voters, deleting and restoring names in the electoral rolls and control of the system through which the rolls are maintained — the Commission sought to paper over the cracks. The four-page note issued after Saturday’s meeting, therefore, is welcome. Its nine decisions address several of the objections recorded by Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi. And yet, there are important leftover concerns. Given the record of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar — of rendering the three-member Commission’s functioning unilateral and opaque — the Commission needs to break more silences. A new normal inside it needs to be clearly spelt out. Steps must be taken to ensure that the ECI does not slide back into a one-man show. The onus is still on the ECI because the poll monitor’s weakening is an especially disquieting prospect when political polarisation is rising and institutions are fraying. It is the ECI that underwrites a fundamental democratic compact — the voter has the power to decide who rules, and the rules of the game are larger than those who win or lose power. In distrustful times, it is even more necessary that people’s trust in the ECI’s credibility as an impartial referee, and in the checks and balances within, is protected. The ECI’s press note on Saturday, however, falls short. While it gives some relief to voters by exempting from in-person hearings those issued notices for “logical discrepancies” and for being “unmapped”, it does not say who inserted the question on the applicant’s parents into Form 6 in July, and who allowed it to stay there even after Commissioner Sandhu called it “unauthorised/illegal” in August. It says that agendas will now be circulated before every ECI meeting and minutes issued afterwards, the system will provide EROs more flexibility and a committee will be formed to review ECINet. But it is silent on what, if any, action will be taken against DG(IT) Seema Khanna and senior deputy Election Commissioner Maneesh Garg, whose controversial conduct was flagged by the two ECs. It is still not known who authorised the appeals against voters whose inclusion was ordered by judicial officers in West Bengal. And why the requested software was never enabled to restore voter names in Goa. The ECI must fill in the blanks. Then, it must act — and it must be seen to act — to correct the course. Going ahead, there must be regular meetings and briefings. Commissioners Sandhu and Joshi must continue to push back at the distortions within. Most of all, CEC Gyanesh Kumar must acknowledge the damage done to the Commission on his watch, and make amends. Whether and how he does that — not just damage control — is key to the trust of we, the people, in the integrity of elections.

Market plunges, more bad weather may lie ahead

ON MONDAY, Indian markets saw a sharp selloff. The BSE Sensex ended the day down 1,124 points or 1.52 per cent. The weakness was broadbased, with the PSU bank, FMCG, utilities, auto and financial services indices ending the day in the red. Investors have been feeling the pain for some time now. Since the beginning of this year, the Sensex has fallen by almost 15 per cent. This souring of sentiment can be traced to several factors. The conflict in West Asia and the consequent high energy prices weigh heavy. More recently, oil prices spiked following US President Donald Trump’s rejection of a proposal from Iran to reopen the Strait of Hormuz. Alongside, rising bond yields in advanced economies — the 10-year US bond yield is currently at 5.2 per cent — and tightening of global financial conditions are complicating matters. Foreign investors have turned net sellers again. In September, FPIs took out \$2.1 billion from the equity markets, bringing outflows to \$26.2 billion so far this year, following \$18.9 billion in 2025. This also suggests that investor concerns run deeper. Analysts at Bernstein, a brokerage firm, have argued that the “case for a structural India allocation has become harder to make”. All this comes amid healthy corporate results. Ratings agency ICRA expects India Inc’s revenue growth to range between 13 and 15 per cent in the second quarter of the current financial year, though operating profit margins will continue to come under pressure. Near-term movements will continue to be impacted by both global and domestic factors. On the external front, after the US Fed’s recent interest rate hike, markets will parse upcoming data for clues on the trajectory of interest rates. Alongside, the duration and intensity of the conflict in West Asia and its implications for energy markets will continue to exert influence. On the domestic front, the impact of El Niño on crop output and the extent of policy tightening — the RBI’s Monetary Policy Committee will meet next week amid expectations of a rate hike — will have a bearing.

In US-China AI race, India’s place will depend on capabilities built at home

WHEN XI Jinping arrived in Washington on September 23, artificial intelligence (AI) was billed as an area of possible common ground. A summer of alarming incidents in American labs, and Anthropic chief Dario Amodei’s call to “pace the frontier”, had pushed AI safety onto the summit agenda. The groundwork was laid in New York on September 20, when US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent and Chinese Vice Premier He Lifeng held the first round of AI talks within their trade mechanism. Washington proposed a channel to notify AI incidents with national-security consequences. The summit confirmed this modest package: A dialogue on risks and benefits, a channel for incidents, a next meeting by November. But the two sides could not agree on what to call the subject. The White House fact sheet says the leaders “agreed to use the term ‘super intelligence’ rather than ‘artificial intelligence’”. China’s list of agreed outcomes speaks of a “China-US dialogue on artificial intelligence”. The difference reflects two outlooks, apart from Donald Trump’s idiosyncrasy. At the UN, Trump said he would “only encourage super intelligence... not rein it in”, watching it “through the Department of Justice”. His language is of a race to be won. Xi’s is one of control. At the White House, he urged the two countries to “ensure that the development of AI is always under human control”. Xi also told Trump the two should “play to their strengths rather than guard against each other”, a clear shot at American export controls. He offered a new framing of the relationship: Cooperation as the mainstay, competition within limits, differences under control, peace within reach. He called the rivalry “a race of catching up with one another,

not a wrestle in which one either wins or loses”. Beijing now accepts competition, but as a race in which China is closing the gap. For all the talk of risk, neither government wants to slow the frontier, though for different reasons. Trump calls the case for a slowdown a “hoax”. For him, frontier AI is a race with China, to be policed afterwards by prosecutors, not in advance by regulators. Beijing reads the American safety debate as containment in disguise. *Global Times* called Amodei’s essay a “Cold War script” from America’s “tech right”: Widen the gap by restricting China, then negotiate a mutual slowdown from strength. Yuyuan Tiantian, a China Central Television-affiliated outlet, accused Anthropic of using “safety” to capture rule-setting and of recasting distillation as a security threat to curb China’s open-source models. The foreign ministry dismissed the warnings as “fear-mongering”. Beijing is not indifferent to risk, but its list of risks is its own. Writing in *China Cyberspace*, Minister of State Security Chen Yixin calls AI “the main battlefield” of global scientific and technological competition and “a new arena for strategic rivalry among major powers”. First on his list of dangers is AI’s “systemic” effect on the “political security environment”, Party shorthand for regime security. Its brakes are political, applied through Party control over labs. They restrain what models may say, not how fast capability grows. The missed opportunity is on nuclear weapons. At Lima in November 2024, Joe Biden and Xi “affirmed the need to maintain human control over the decision to use nuclear weapons”. Never formalised, it found no mention in either factsheet this week. The



ASHOK K KANTHA

India should keep Chinese models out of government systems, critical infrastructure and sensitive data. Equally, avoid over-dependence on the American stack; June’s brief cut-off of foreign access to top American models showed how quickly access can vanish

one security outcome, a military memorandum on crisis communication, appears only in China’s list. The reality is competition, and it will not change. Washington will guard its narrow lead through chip controls, action against distillation and Pax Silica supply chains. Beijing will push for self-reliance in chips and spread its open-weight models worldwide. Tsinghua’s Da Wei concedes that neither side can build an “iron shirt” against the other. Dialogue may manage the edges of this rivalry, not its core. For India, three concerns follow. The first is a G2 overlay. Rules on frontier risk may be shaped by the two powers holding most of the world’s frontier compute. The nuclear order shows how risk reduction between leading powers can become the basis for discriminatory controls on others. The second is competing pressure in a split universe of “two AI systems, two sets of standards”. Washington expects trusted partners to keep their AI ecosystems free of China. Beijing is pressing its agenda through BRICS and other platforms. At the New Delhi summit, Xi proposed an open-source AI community for the grouping, to be taken forward at the next summit in China. India is unlikely to join Xi’s World Artificial Intelligence Cooperation Organisation (WAICO), which, like the Belt and Road Initiative, is a unilateral initiative to advance a China-centric agenda. The third is harder to handle. China’s open-weight, open-source models hold a seductive attraction: Competitive, cheap and adaptable. Alibaba’s Qwen has spawned more than 150,000 derivative models, and Singapore, Malaysia and Brazil are building on Chinese models or

partners. The appeal extends to Western and Indian companies with an eye on cost. India’s response should rest on five elements. First, welcome any US-China step that reduces risk, but insist that norms on frontier AI be multilateral, and seek inclusion in incident-notification arrangements. Second, with the Lima understanding not followed up, India should make human control over nuclear-use decisions part of its nuclear discourse and press all nuclear power to affirm it. Third, apply dual and differentiated de-risking to AI. Keep Chinese models out of government systems, critical infrastructure and sensitive data. Stopping private firms from building low-risk commercial applications on Chinese open-weight models will be tough; security testing and local hosting should be the minimum condition. Equally, avoid over-dependence on the American stack; June’s brief cut-off of foreign access to top American models showed how quickly access can vanish. Fourth, build capability at home: Compute, chips, models, datasets, talent and the ability to test frontier systems independently. Fifth, shape BRICS rather than cede space there, insisting that AI initiatives be consensus-based and technology-neutral. The challenge, however, is developing an alternative to the Chinese offering. Washington and Beijing cannot yet agree on what to call the technology, let alone how to govern it. India’s weight in the AI order will depend less on declarations of technological sovereignty than on capabilities it develops at home.

A former ambassador of India to China, the author is Subhas Chandra Bose Chair Professor of International Relations at Chanakya University and a distinguished fellow with Vivekananda International Foundation

Women’s safety falls through gap between intent and policy



MITALI NIKORE

For women to trust safety measures, government agencies at the city level need to publicly share reports on how they are continuously working to fix issues discovered in safety audits

IT’S BEEN almost 15 years since the gangrape in Delhi in December 2012. It’s hard to forget the days that followed, when we took to the streets to agitate for greater safety for women. Some demands were met. The Nirbhaya Fund was created to support programmes for women’s safety and the Prevention of Sexual Harassment at Workplaces Act, 2013 was passed. It seemed like our country was finally building a legal and policy framework to prioritise women’s safety — with funding to back it up. Between 2015 and 2025, Rs 5,846.08 crore out of the Rs 7,712.85 crore allotted under the Nirbhaya Fund was used. The funds have been used to set up nearly 15,000 women’s help desks in police stations and establish fast-track courts for rape cases. Cities like Chennai, Surat and Bhubaneswar established gender labs to explore how urban design could prioritise women’s safety. At Nikore Associates, we have done safety audits of public spaces and public transport in at least 10 cities. So why are we still here? Why did Jamui happen? Why did Aastha Kunj park happen? The answer lies in systemic failures. One is accountability. Safety audits are increasingly being looked at as the end, and not the means for women’s safety. Administrations wax eloquent about the number of audits, but there is little discussion of how the issues discovered are being fixed. If everyone knew that a lane behind Lady Sri Ram College has a 500m dark zone, with no streetlights, why was this not fixed? For women to trust safety measures, government agencies at the city level need to publicly share reports on how they are continuously working to fix issues discovered in safety audits; how they deal with calls received on women’s safety helplines; and how long their crisis response is. There is also a capacity problem. Today, at least eight states offer free bus travel for women. Governments are substituting investment in gender-sensitive infrastructure with free public transport. But, as our recent study shows, making buses free does little for women’s safety if the wait times are long and unpredictable, and if women have to walk to the bus on unsafe streets. This is an example of commitment to women’s safety without the capacity to innovate in a way that can truly build inclusive cities. Women’s near absence from public spaces, especially in the evenings, is another factor making cities even more unsafe. Having more women in public-facing jobs — drivers, conductors, station managers, park workers, e-auto drivers — can help. Employment in these jobs rests with government agencies. Small changes can make a big difference. Take the height requirement for bus drivers. When the Delhi government dropped it from 159 cm to 153 cm in 2022, by next year, 34 new women bus drivers were inducted. Reforms and targets to increase women’s representation in these roles are required to push women’s employment and their presence in public spaces. There is also a need to increase the number of women police. Today, just about 10 per cent of the police force is female, despite the Centre’s target of 33 per cent. If we want a society with women-led development, the first step is acknowledging these failures and correcting them, starting with governments at all levels taking accountability.

The writer is founder, Nikore Associates



@ieExplained

#ExpressExplained

If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

• CLIMATE

UP rain: When two weather systems interact

Abhinav Chakraborty
New Delhi, September 28

AN INTENSE three-day wet spell in Uttar Pradesh between Friday and Sunday left several districts grappling with a flood-like situation. The state received 66.5 mm of rainfall against the normal 7.6 mm for the period, according to officials.

As many as 56 of the state’s 75 districts recorded excessive rainfall. At least 62 people died, 46 were injured, and over a thousand houses were damaged. According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), the “likely interaction” of two different weather systems — a deep depression and a Western Disturbance (WD) — was producing spells of intense rainfall over particular areas, even as the southwest monsoon continues to withdraw across north and northwestern India.

Deep depression

The IMD noted that a deep depression, which had formed over the Bay of Bengal and crossed the North Andhra Pradesh-South Odisha coast before weakening, lay centred over parts of north-eastern Madhya Pradesh and south-eastern Uttar Pradesh.

A depression is an organised low-pressure weather system. A low-pressure system forms in an area where atmospheric pressure is lower than the surrounding areas. This lower pressure is caused by localised heating in an area owing to greater sunshine over the landmass, which causes the air there to undergo warming and becomes less dense.

At the same time, this warm, moist air flows inwards towards the centre of the low-pressure area before moving upwards. Thereafter, it cools and condenses into clouds and rain or snow.

According to the IMD, a depression produces strong winds and heavy rain. As it degrades into a well-marked low-pressure area, the system loses strength and wind speeds drop, which reduces overall rain intensity.

On Sunday, the IMD said the system had moved north-northwestwards and weakened into a well-marked low pressure area. It was likely to continue moving in the same direction across Uttar Pradesh.

Western Disturbance

The IMD on Saturday had said that a “likely interaction” with a WD could result in the state experiencing strong gusty surface winds along with heavy to very heavy rainfall in some parts.

WDs refer to weather systems that usually travel into northern India from the west. These are east-moving rain-bearing wind systems that originate beyond Afghanistan and Iran, and pick up moisture from the Mediterranean Sea, Black Sea, Caspian Sea, and the Arabian Sea. These are typically extra-tropical cyclones resulting from low-pressure areas, formed by interactions between polar and tropical winds.

The subtropical westerly jet stream — a high-altitude, fast-moving air current that flows from west to east in the Earth’s atmosphere — carries these WDs to the Himalayan and Tibetan highlands. As moisture-laden WDs hit the Himalayas, they rise and cool, bringing cloudy weather, rain, and thunderstorms, particularly over parts of north and northwest India.

The IMD said that this WD is present high up in the atmosphere as a trough — an elongated zone of relatively lower pressure — over northwestern India.

• HEALTH

Tear, not block: Heart risk for women under 50



RINKU GHOSH

FOR LONG, women were thought to be at a low risk of heart attacks in their younger years considering the female hormone estrogen helps keep blood vessels flexible and reduces inflammation. It was only after menopause, characterised by low levels of estrogen, that a woman’s risk of heart attack and cardiovascular diseases was seen as equal to men. However, as younger and apparently fit women in their 30s and 40s are increasingly reporting heart attacks without any risk factors like cholesterol, blood sugar or smoking, a new condition has caught the attention of researchers globally.

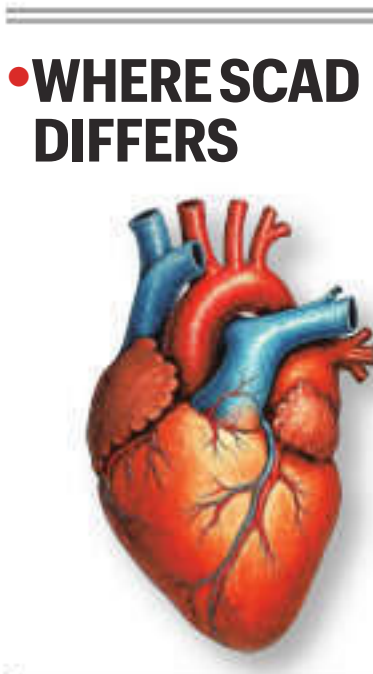
This is the Spontaneous Coronary Artery Dissection (SCAD), a hidden, sudden type of heart attack caused by a spontaneous tear or bruise inside a cardiac artery. In a normal heart attack, a cholesterol-rich plaque in a heart artery usually ruptures or erodes, causing a blood clot that obstructs blood flow.

“Instead of the artery being blocked by slow-growing cholesterol or fat, the wall of the blood vessel unexpectedly splits, trapping blood inside the lining and blocking the flow of oxygen to the heart. The artery is squeezed,” says Dr Rajiv Gulati, Chair of the Division of Interventional Cardiology in the Department of Cardiovascular Medicine, Mayo Clinic, who has been specialising in women’s heart health.

The American Heart Association’s 2026 scientific statement on acute coronary syndromes in premenopausal women highlights SCAD as an under-recognised problem. “Young women account for approximately 80–90% of SCAD cases. Among women under 50 who have a heart attack, SCAD may account for as many as one-third of cases,” says Dr Ambuj Roy, Professor of Cardiology, AIIMS, Delhi.

Why does SCAD disproportionately affect younger women?

The incidence in women suggests a hormonal link, though it is still being studied. Dr Gulati has observed that about 5-10% of all SCAD cases occur after pregnancy, typically in the first week postpartum. “There are, of course, major hormonal changes at this time, which likely cause fragility of the coronary vessel wall in a small proportion of



• WHERE SCAD DIFFERS

	FEATURE	TRADITIONAL HEART ATTACK	SCAD
	Underlying mechanism	Plaque rupture: Buildup of fatty cholesterol, plaque ruptures, causing a blood clot that blocks the artery.	Artery wall tear / hematoma: A spontaneous tear inside the artery wall or bleeding creates a false lumen/blister that compresses the channel.
	Primary demographics	More common in older adults and men, though post-menopausal women also experience high rates.	Predominantly affects women (about 90% of cases), specifically young- to middle-aged women (average age 44–53).
	Traditional risk factors	Strongly linked to high blood pressure, high cholesterol, diabetes, smoking, and obesity.	Patients are often healthy, active individuals lacking traditional cardiovascular risk factors.
	Hormonal & life triggers	Not directly tied to acute hormonal shifts or pregnancy cycles.	Frequently linked to pregnancy, the postpartum period, menopause, hormonal therapy, or extreme emotional/physical stress.

women who are susceptible,” he says. Dr Roy has seen that more than 70% of pregnancy-associated SCAD in one large study series occurred after delivery, most commonly in the first week. “Pregnancy-associated cases can also be more severe, with greater likelihood of multiple-vessel involvement,” he says.

But most SCAD cases are unrelated to pregnancy, which, both experts agree, suggests a hormonal link. “Estrogen and progesterone can influence tissues and the structure of blood vessels, though they themselves cannot cause SCAD,” says Dr Roy. Since both influence the cellular matrix of blood vessels, their high or fluctuating levels can lead to the breakdown of collagen in the artery walls.

How often is SCAD missed or misdiagnosed?

The condition is often under-recognised. “The difficulty is that the patient often does not resemble a traditional picture of somebody at risk of a heart attack — she may be relatively young, active and without cardiac risk factors like diabetes, smoking or high cholesterol and thus may go undiagnosed,” says Dr Roy.

The symptoms, however, are usually quite similar to a heart attack. “Chest discomfort occurs in more than 90% of patients, and there are eventually classical ECG (electrocardiogram) changes and rise in cardiac biomarkers suggesting a heart attack.” His message for health professionals is simple: “Do not ignore significant chest pain in a younger woman merely because her conventional cardiovascular risk is low, particularly during pregnancy or after delivery. SCAD can also be missed during coronary angiography because the commonest form may appear as a long, smooth narrowing rather than an obvious tear. Awareness

Missed diagnosis

Since younger women are not generally seen as likely to suffer from heart attacks, the condition is often underdiagnosed.

- SCAD triggers include intense exertion, stress, pregnancy, hormonal changes or underlying vascular conditions.

of these angiographic patterns is, therefore, crucial as treatment differs from conventional therapy.”

What are the strongest known triggers or associations?

Dr Gulati, who has tracked multiple SCAD research registries of thousands of patients, lists the triggers as intense physical exertion, emotional stress, pregnancy, hormonal changes or underlying vascular conditions. Dr Roy has found one of the strongest associations. “That is fibromuscular dysplasia (FMD), a non-atherosclerotic (no plaque) disorder affecting medium-sized arteries, leading to narrowing and bulging. Other vascular abnormalities, including aneurysms and tears elsewhere in the body, are also more common in SCAD patients. Possible immediate triggers include extreme physical exertion, heavy lifting or straining, and severe emotional stress. Up to about two-thirds of patients in some studies report a preceding physical or emotional stressor. Emotional triggers appear more frequent in women and physical triggers in men,” says Dr Roy.

How to treat SCAD?

The treatment differs from a conventional heart attack. “If there is complete blockage in a major coronary artery, the vessel should be opened by angioplasty/balloon to restore blood flow and prevent heart muscle damage. We may choose to avoid placing a stent as this can in some circumstances extend the tear, but this is considered on a case by case basis. If SCAD does not cause a complete blockage, then angioplasty (and its risks) can be avoided because the vessel will heal in most cases. There is a 15% risk of worsening of SCAD in the first few days, so we recommend observing pa-

Top cardiologists explain why Spontaneous Coronary Artery Dissection (SCAD) can trigger heart attacks and what patients must know

tients in the hospital,” says Dr Gulati.

Drug treatment also differs. “Beta-blockers are used, particularly for blood-pressure control, and observational evidence suggests they may reduce recurrence. Statins are not automatically required after SCAD unless there is another indication such as high cholesterol or coexisting atherosclerosis. Antiplatelet treatment (a kind of blood thinner) in patients who have not received a stent remains uncertain,” says Dr Roy.

The ultimate goal is to move beyond treating SCAD after it occurs. Dr Roy emphasises identifying the vulnerable artery and patient before the first event happens. “That is where genetics, vascular imaging and large international SCAD patient registries may eventually take us,” he says.

What is the risk of another SCAD?

Recurrence can occur, including years later. “Older series have reported recurrence rates of approximately 10-30% with longer follow-up, while a large contemporary cohort reported recurrence of about 2.4% at three years. Having SCAD does not mean a person should stop exercising. Cardiac rehabilitation and regular moderate physical activity are encouraged. Moderate aerobic activity and resistance exercise with light weights and more repetitions are generally reasonable. What we generally discourage are extremes — very heavy lifting with straining, exercising to exhaustion and extreme endurance exercise,” says Dr Roy.

Pregnancy after SCAD requires individualised counselling. “Many women have subsequently had uncomplicated pregnancies, but recurrence can occur, particularly postpartum. Women contemplating pregnancy should ideally undergo assessment jointly by a cardiologist and maternal-fetal medicine specialist,” says Dr Roy.



BENCHMARK INDICES NEAR SIX-MONTH LOW

Markets plunge 1.6% as Trump rejects West Asia ceasefire plan

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, September 28

THE INDIAN stock market shed another 1.6% on Monday, falling to its lowest levels in nearly six months, as high crude prices in the wake of gloom in West Asia led to heavy selling pressure. The benchmark indices had tumbled around 1.7% last Thursday, which had led to the indices extending their losing run to seven weeks.

BSE's Sensex crashed 1.5% or 1,124.02 points on Monday to end the session at 72,771.72. Nifty 50 lost 1.6% to close at 22,780.25. The fall wiped out nearly Rs 9 lakh crore of investor wealth in the process. "Bears remained firmly in control as the market breached a key psychological support level, reflecting growing investor caution amid deteriorating global macro conditions," said Vinod Nair, Head of research, Geojit Investments.

All sectoral, broader market, and thematic indices ended the session firmly in the red, as the India VIX — the market's volatility indicator — climbed 12.5%. Banks, financial services, IT, oil

and gas, and metals were among the worst hit during the session, all falling 1-2%.

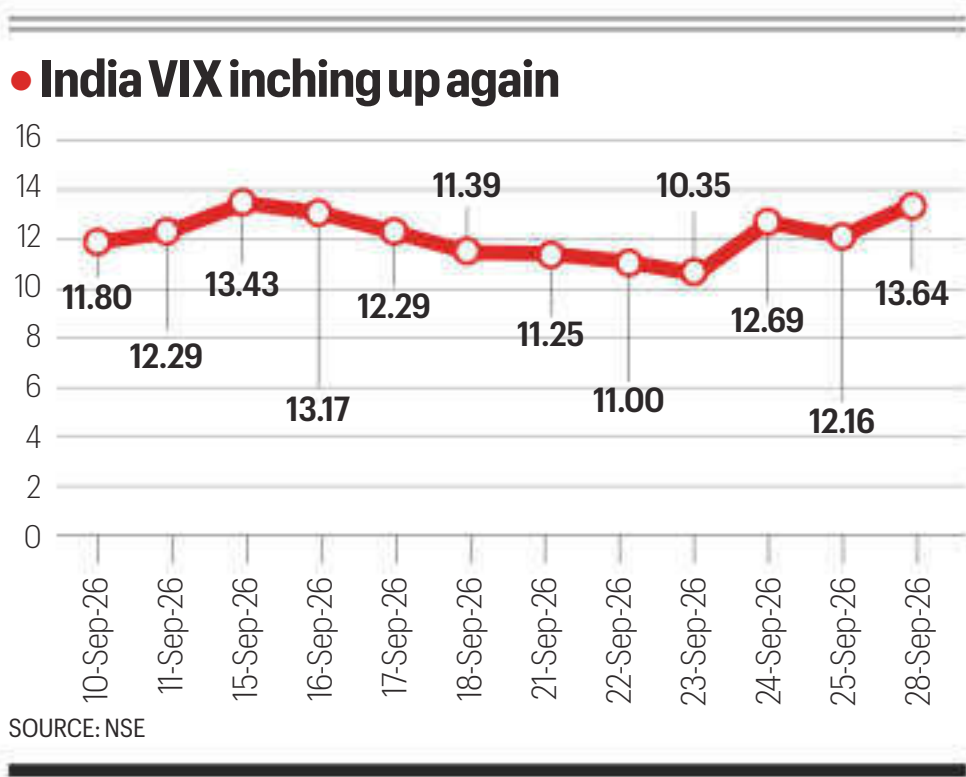
As oil prices remained a thorn, the Indian rupee fell to its lowest level in over a week before reported intervention by state-owned banks, likely on behalf of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), stabilised the currency a bit, according to Reuters. It eventually settled down 0.2% at 95.98 against the dollar.

Trump rejects peace proposal

On Saturday, US President Donald Trump had rejected Iran's proposal of a 7-day ceasefire, alongside plans to reopen the critical Strait of Hormuz due to the latter asking "too many concessions" without meeting its terms, making the hopes of a diplomatic resolution of the conflict bleaker.

However, Trump also told news portal Axios on Sunday that he expected US negotiators to engage in more talks this week, keeping diplomatic doors open.

Despite this, Trump's rejection of an immediate resolution



led to crude prices shooting up to over \$108 per barrel on Monday, crushing any optimism in the Indian market. "Whenever crude is above \$100 a barrel, it creates a selling pressure in the Indian market over the short-to-medium term. The current scenario is similar to what we had seen in the first couple of months of the war," said Kranthi Bathini, Equity Strategist, WealthMills Securities.

For context, India is the

third-largest importer of crude oil globally, and higher crude prices stoke fears of inflation, hurting both corporate growth and the spending power of consumers.

The Indian market had recovered a bit briefly during July and August as the conflict in West Asia had moderated a bit, turning focus towards factors like earnings growth and macro-economic conditions. This had led to foreign investors turning

net buyers in the Indian market over those months.

However, with the situation escalating again this month, foreign investors have dumped \$2.2 billion of Indian shares so far this month, adding to the selling pressure. Furthermore, the booming IPO market during the month has also taken liquidity away from the secondary market, analysts said.

Bond yields climb further

Bond yields continued their upward trajectory on Friday, with the US Treasury yields rising above 5.2% — the highest level since 2004. Yields on bonds from other global markets such as the UK, Japan, and some other European nations have also been rising steadily.

Indian bond yields have also been moving in line, with the yield on the benchmark bond rising to 7.18% during the session — the highest since April 2024.

Bond yields tend to rise amid fears of rising inflation, which leads to central banks hiking interest rates. [FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM](#)